

Giant spectacle: Aryna Sabalenka and Naomi Osaka delivered the match of the tournament, with the World No. 1 prevailing 7-5, 6-3. REUTERS

interview, an extroverted Sabalenka displayed her glee by dancing to the background music.

But she had only herself to blame for her shocking quarterfinal collapse against 25th-seeded Diana Shnaider. The Russian left-hander, who had never played a No. 1 before and owned only one win over a top-five opponent, trailed 6-3, 4-1, 30-love with Sabalenka serving.

But wind is the biggest equaliser in tennis, and when Sabalenka's all-out first-strike game started misfiring in the swirling winds, the emotional champion unravelled in frustration. Meanwhile, Shnaider kept her head and fought back brilliantly for a stunning 3-6, 7-5, 6-0 upset.

Defending champion Coco Gauff's 4-6, 7-6(1), 6-4 third-round loss to 28th-seeded Anastasia Potapova was not a total surprise, given Gauff's performances on clay before Paris.

The 22-year-old American had dropped three straight three-set matches against quality foes — to Karolina Muchova at Stuttgart, Linda Noskova at Madrid and Elina Svitolina in the Rome final. Potapova had also beaten Gauff in their last two encounters.

What about Iga Swiatek? Was she a player in decline, as her mediocre 6-3 win-loss record on European clay this season indicated? Or could she suddenly regain the form that won Roland Garros titles in 2020, 2022, 2023 and 2024, and, stunningly, Wimbledon in 2025?

Polish fans believed the latter. By the hundreds, they purchased tickets and booked hotel rooms. Some brought Polish flags and signs such as 'Poland Garros' to signify her domination on the terre battue this decade.

Their hopes rose when Swiatek defeated fellow countrywoman Magda Linette 6-4, 6-4 in the third round. Her viciously spinning

Western forehand was back. It produced 160 more rpm than last year and with a safer trajectory of nine centimetres more net clearance.

In the end, Marta Kostyuk (**below**), riding a red-hot 15-match winning streak, thrashed the former Queen of Clay 7-5, 6-1 on Swiatek's 25th birthday.

A former teen prodigy now 23, Kostyuk had learned to control her emotions and harness her power and exceptional athleticism — she performed a backflip after winning in Madrid.

Most improved was her 'serve plus one' aggressive formula, which shortened rallies to an average of 3.8 shots when she served. "[I'd] never taken a set off her, it's incredible," Kostyuk said. "I still cannot believe it."

Off-court battles

It may have been a shocker, but it was no fluke. In the first all-Ukraine Grand Slam quarter-final, Kostyuk outplayed Svitolina 6-3, 2-6, 6-2, seizing 13 of the last 14 points, nine on clean winners.

That made Kostyuk the first Ukrainian woman to reach the French Open semifinals, while the disappointed Svitolina dropped to 0-6 in Roland Garros quarterfinals.

Although Kostyuk defeated Andreeva in the Madrid final, the

pressure of the war in her beloved homeland and competing in her first Slam semifinal took an emotional toll. Kostyuk had no idea how to play in the swirling wind, nervously spraying errors everywhere. When the roof finally closed late in the second set, it was too late for a comeback, and the more poised



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